

a sadistic mind can simply make your system crash, needing time and effort to be set it right. Or possibly cause data loss even. We know that security is something we must take seriously, especially if we are talking about offices, small ones even. So we'll leave it at that and tell you what you can do to secure your Linux box.

Firstly, we have to understand that there is no absolute security. If someone is determined to get access to your system, they can, provided it is physically accessible to them. So, the first thing to do is ensure that the computer is physically safe. If you feel like it, just lock it up in a safe. (ok, ok, we were kidding!). On the serious side, try to ensure that not everyone can come and sit on your computer. Especially if you have critical information on it.

Having said this, let us move to different stages of security, starting right from the most basic, the BIOS password setting. Most BIOS allow you to set a 'system password' by which the computer won't even fully boot without a valid password. Every time the computer is started, the user will have to key in the correct password in order to be able to even start the OS. While this sounds nice and safe is not foolproof. If someone has a simple screwdriver, he can manage to reset the BIOS by shorting particular pins on the motherboard or by taking off the BIOS battery for sometime, thereby removing the password.

This brings us to the next line of defense, the user and root password. Of course, you are expected not to keep sharing your password with everyone. A password is private, remember. Now you know that without a password, it is not possible to do any operations. Linux does not even allow you 'inside' without the password. So, this is safety enough, right? Alas no!

There is a known loophole in Linux by which anyone can make a small modification to the boot loader and start the machine in single user mode without any password and gain root privileges. So, how would you combat this loophole? This is explained in the box '*Hardening Single User Mode*'.

Another method to prevent entry to Single User Mode is by